

Pay over the course of the pandemic. Over the course of the pandemic, everyone including senior citizens got normalised to video calling apps, and interacting with the healthcare professionals treating them. This familiarity with the technologies, combined with the introduction of new technologies, only means that both patients and doctors are opening up to the promises of telemedicine. Going ahead, we can expect to see an uptick in telemedicine technologies. ISRO is in the process of providing critical telemedicine equipment, particularly to remote locations in the country. Private organisations and technology vendors are all rushing to increase capacity, in India and around the world. According to predictions made by Deloitte, the year 2021 will see a rise to five per cent of virtual visits to in person medical visits, a number that will rise from one per cent in 2019. Each digit change in the percentage translates to 8.5 billion doctor's visits in cyberspace. In fact, going forward, it may well be possible that people actually prefer virtual visits to in person visits, especially if it is unsafe for the patient to step out. Steven Templeton, President & CEO of ThereCare says, "The practice of visiting a doctor's office is no longer a simple process and can be a matter of life or death. In fact, there is a strong feeling from most people that going to a doctor or urgent care is too risky."

20 RISE OF THE ROBOTS

Any time the human workforce becomes more expensive, there is an increase in pressure on automation, so there is a direct relation between recession and an increase in robotics. Combined with the social distancing norms where having two people too close together in a workplace can be dangerous, or with lockdown restrictions where people are not allowed to leave home at all, the implementation of robotics is only projected to increase. Robotic vacuum cleaners, disinfectant sprayers and UV

washers in particular, are expected to see an increase in adoption.

As the world went into a lockdown, the demands on delivery services were only increasing, leading to the rapid development of all kinds of robotic delivery services, including drones that fly pizza straight into your balconies. One example is of a robotic researcher at Iowa State University, that was one of the few that was able to continue doing its research work even when the rest of the scientists were stuck at home. The system uses a robotic arm and a rover to study the effects of drought on plants, by growing various plants

industries are undergoing a structural change due to the pandemic, there lies a huge scope for the robotics and automation sector. Industrial and consumer robots have managed to find their ways in different aspects of human lives, and their demand will increase multifold. The sectors which will benefit from robotics are manufacturing, facility management, and other consumer-facing sectors like hospitality, education, health-care, retail, banking, etc. Once Indian labor combines its potential with robots, businesses will exceed their average potential. The disposable incomes of Indian households will enable them



Credit: Iowa State University

RoAD continuing research in the lab even though everything around shuts down

with different amounts of water. Pat Schnable, director of the Plant Sciences Institute explains, "The RoAD system makes it possible for researchers to spend more time carefully designing and analysing experiments and less time simply caring for and measuring plants. As an added benefit, RoAD probably collects more consistent data than do humans."

But it is not just in high-tech American university laboratories that we can see more robots, they are very likely to become increasingly common here too, over the year ahead, particularly robots in retail environments and automated sanitisation systems. Mr. Rajeev Karwal, Founder Chairman of Milagrow Robots, elaborates, "2020 has been a year when India took a big step towards self-sufficiency, and people woke up to the robotic wonders. As numerous

to opt for not only smart but safe solutions for residential chores. As a result, very soon, the market for consumer and floor cleaning robots will explode."

Founder & CEO at Hi-Tech Robotic Systemz LTD, Mr. Anuj Kapuria shares similar sentiments, "This year 2020 has totally changed not just the consumer behavior but also how organizations view their supply chain and related digitization and automation needs. There will be a significant rise in the adoption of AI and Robotics in the coming year, perpetuated by the social distancing norms, contact less deliveries and higher productivity along with less manpower dependence. While the vaccine availability will ease and smoothen the restrictions in business operations, it is AI and Robotics that will lead the way in heralding the new normal." 